



BANDEEP SINGH

EXCERPTS

“SURAIYA HELD HER LIPS UP TO ME, READY FOR A KISS”

“The shot is ready!” came a voice. In the shot, she had to go and stand by a bed of flowers. I had to go behind her, pluck a flower and present it to her, saying a sweet something. “Let’s do it straightaway, as it comes spontaneously, and naturally. No rehearsals!” I suggested. “Yes.” She was ready. The camera rolled. She went and stood by the flower bed. I sneaked from behind, plucked a flower and threw it up in the air. As it came down, I caught it between my lips. She plucked it from between my lips, and kissed it. The camera caught the action, the director was happy, and everybody clapped. We shook hands, and let the handshake linger. I pressed her hand. She pressed mine back. From good friends to close friends, and then to lovers. And our love affair became the talk of the town, nay, of the whole country.

There was not a day when Suraiya and I did not meet or talk to each other on the phone. I was in love. But the granny who controlled the ethical, moral and religious code of the family, as also its purse strings, became the main opponent

I BOUGHT ONE OF THE COSTLIEST RINGS THAT WOULD ADORN HER FINGER. I WAS IN SEVENTH HEAVEN. WE WERE ENGAGED.



drinking habit. There are travels—beach swims with Frank Capra, a Rome meeting with Gregory Peck, dinners with Shirley MacLaine, and a marathon appointment with Charlie Chaplin. In between intimate accounts of furtive sex in trains, on plains, and in hotel rooms, Anand also manages to talk movies, which remain his greatest passion—here he is shooting *Taxi Driver* on no money and in 35 days; there he is doing the opening sequence of *Kala Bazaar* at the premiere of *Mother India*; and here he is again shooting on the last day of the 20th century on New York’s Times Square for yet another ambitious movie. Presidents and prime ministers, novelists and award-winning international directors walk through the pages of a book that is almost as breathlessly bouncy as Bollywood’s oldest superstar. His creativity may have declined in inverse proportion to the age of his discoveries, but at a time when Indian actors are just discovering Hollywood and corporate production, just remember this: he made *Guide* and his banner Navketan produced 40 films. ■

to our relationship. I realized I was no longer welcome at her house, and that Suraiya was a silent prisoner in her family’s hands. The forbidden apple now seemed to be more desirable and most delicious, being out of my reach. It turned me mad. My ego and self-respect at stake, I now understood why young people committed suicide, craving for each other, but not being able to meet. I devised a plan of writing to her and getting Divecha, the cameraman on the sets of *Jeet*, who was very close to her and her family, to pass the letter on to her. I read the note scribbled back by Suraiya. It read, “I cried as I read your letter. It is mutual. I love you. I, too, am dying to meet you. Call me tomorrow at 7.00 p.m.”

Next day, I called her exactly at the time she had given. I heard granny’s voice reply instead, saying, “Who’s that?” and a weeping shriek from Suraiya in the background, while the phone got disconnected. Then I rang her number again. “She’s been crying,” her mother said. “Don’t call Suraiya. But you can meet her tomorrow.” She was sitting by the water-